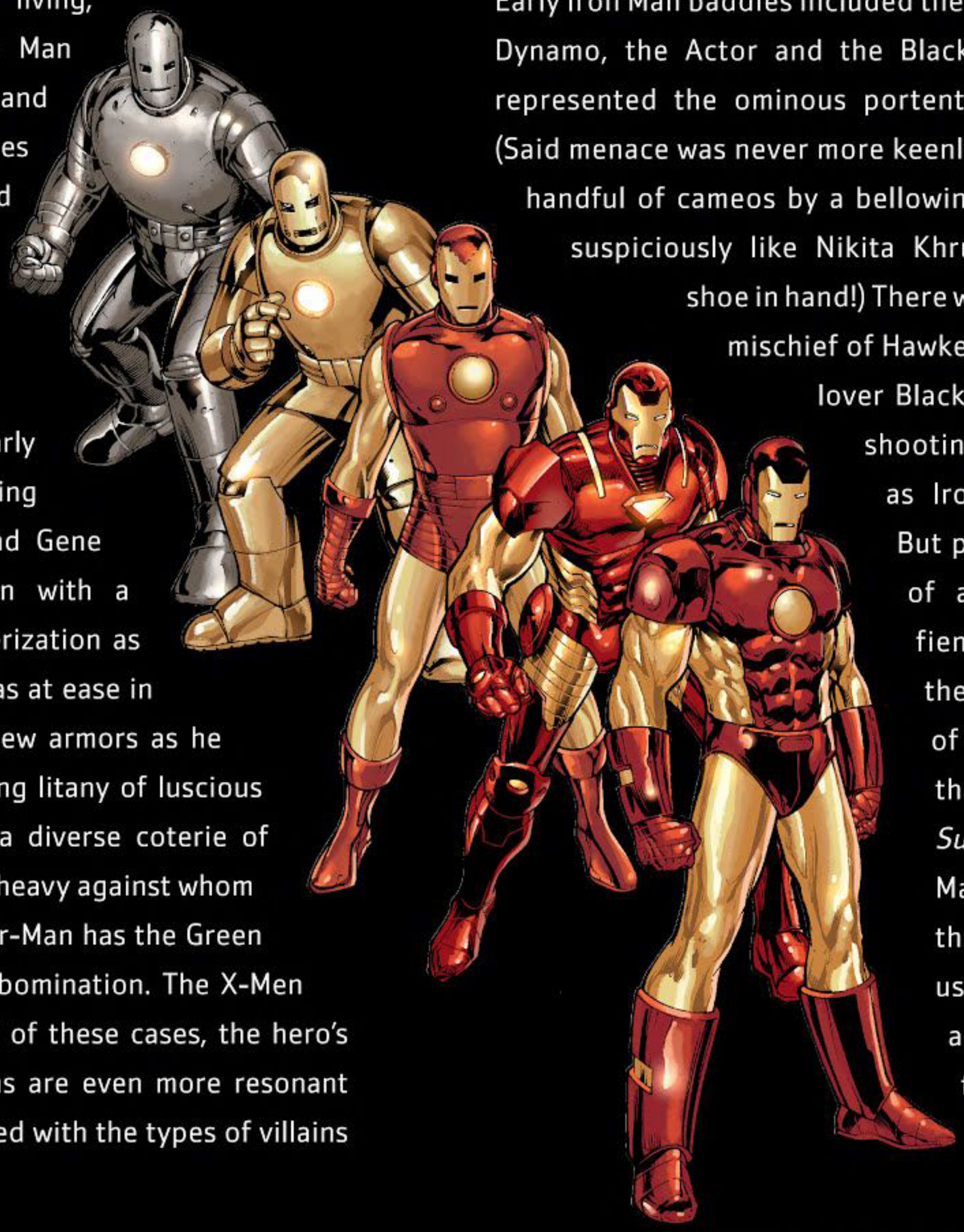
to save Yinsen's life, the "living, walking, conquering" Iron Man upstages his wicked captor and returns to the United States to symbolize America's Cold War capacity to outthink, outdesign and outsmart the Soviet war machine.

Stan Lee and his early collaborators — including Don Heck, Larry Lieber and Gene Colan — gifted Iron Man with a strong, distinctive characterization as a swinging, smart playboy, as at ease in his workshop developing new armors as he was charming a never-ending litany of luscious ladies. Iron Man also had a diverse coterie of villains. Every hero needs a heavy against whom he can prove himself. Spider-Man has the Green Goblin. The Hulk has the Abomination. The X-Men have Magneto. And in each of these cases, the hero's many layers and dimensions are even more resonant with readers when contrasted with the types of villains he attracts.



Art by Carlo Pagulayan, from *All-New Iron Manual* (July 2008)

Early Iron Man baddies included the cold warriors the Crimson Dynamo, the Actor and the Black Widow — all of whom represented the ominous portents of the Soviet menace. (Said menace was never more keenly observed than in a small handful of cameos by a bellowing bureaucrat who looked suspiciously like Nikita Khrushchev, sometimes with shoe in hand!) There was also the arrow-slinging mischief of Hawkeye — who, in tandem with lover Black Widow, would later start shooting the straight and narrow as Iron Man's fellow Avenger. But perhaps the biggest villain of all was the Mandarin, a fiendish mastermind from the Far East. Also indicative of the communist paranoia that permeated *Tales of Suspense*'s comics fare, the Mandarin was a constant thorn in Iron Man's side, using his ten rings of power and martial-arts prowess to attack the armored Avenger from his exotic Eastern homeland.